

India 'B' in the 2022 Chess Olympiad in Mahabalipuram. It was his performance that was instrumental in India winning the bronze medal. No wonder, Gukesh took the gold on the top board, much like teammates Nihal Sarin on Board Two and Praggnanandhaa on Board Three.

In the 2023 World Cup, in August, Gukesh overtook Anand in live ratings to become World No 9. After winning the two games in the second round against Misratdin Iskandarov, his live rating moved ahead of an almost inactive Anand's. He eventually stayed ahead till the next rating list was published on September 1, 2023, and became the first Indian in 37 years to figure ahead of Anand in FIDE's published rating list.

Though he missed the chance to qualify for the Candidates from the World Cup he did just enough to eventually grab a spot, by finishing second to Fabiano Caruana in the 2023 FIDE Circuit. Since Caruana had already qualified by being third in the World Cup, Gukesh took the spot meant for the FIDE Circuit winner.

But the days running up to the cut-off date to make the grade was suspenseful. Gukesh did his chances a huge favour by winning the 2023 Chennai Grandmasters title in late December. He then waited to see whether Dutch Anish Giri wins the World rapid or blitz titles. Once Giri faltered, Gukesh's path stood clear.

What makes him such a special talent? Many believe that Gukesh's ability to calculate accurately in complicated positions sets him apart. Much like Carlsen, he has the patience to wait for weaknesses or even a move of sub-optimal strength to seize his chance. That's the reason he has managed to emerge stronger from seemingly equal positions even until the late middle-game.

Unlike Praggnanandhaa, Gukesh takes his chances and that's the reason he is involved in more decisive battles than his more famous teammate.

Vidit Gujrathi: Vidit (right) is the one who gets a lot less credit than he deserves. He broke the barrier that kept the likes of P. Harikrishna and K. Sasikiran from firming up their spots among the top-25 players. Vidit surpassed the 2700-rating mark and stayed up there but soon the teen-brigade comprising Nihal Sarin, Praggnanandhaa, Arjun Erigaisi and Gukesh took the focus away from Vidit's consistency. His rise has been gradual but steady like some of his seniors.

It is indeed poetic justice that Vidit finds a place in the Candidates, after missing the route via the World Cup. Not many remember him

